



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 48

WASHINGTON

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Washington's family courts and child-welfare system.

65

WASHINGTON FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
106 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 6, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

24 OF 39

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WASHINGTON AT A GLANCE.

Across 65 Washington families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 106 65 of 65 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$114,250 median across 34 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 64.6% 50.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 65	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 65 of 65	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 24

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Washington families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF WASHINGTON FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	39	\$30,000	\$78,899	\$3,077,050
Lost Wages	29	\$40,000	\$93,984	\$2,725,550
Other Court Fees	21	\$1,000	\$3,919	\$82,300
Therapy / Evaluations	32	\$4,350	\$7,717	\$246,950
Reunification Services	20	\$564	\$9,832	\$196,638
GAL Fees	28	\$3,250	\$8,495	\$237,850
Asset Loss ¹	30	\$60,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (34 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$114,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$60,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		33	2.8 yrs
Total across all families		1,525	127.1 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WASHINGTON

Most families documenting in Washington are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		27	42%
Not provided		16	25%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		11	17%
Case closed: within last 2 years		9	14%
Active case: progress being made		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		28	43%
Family Court Only		23	35%
Unknown		9	14%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		5	8%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		17	26%
5 – 10 years		14	22%
3 – 5 years		11	17%
6 months – 1 year		8	12%
5+ years		6	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		23	35%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		23	35%
Full Custody		8	12%
50/50 Joint		4	6%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		3	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Pierce		7	11%
King		7	11%
Snohomish		5	8%
Clallam		3	5%
Spokane		3	5%
Clark		3	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		23	35%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		15	23%
High Conflict Divorce		8	12%
Other: (Short answer)		4	6%
Family Court		4	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — WASHINGTON

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Washington comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



The system has failed my children, took them from my care after 7 years of raising them since birth, put them in the home where they have been sexually assaulted, physically abused, and severely neglected. Their court restrained me from all contact with my children including [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Cuz Harmon my daughter mentally emotional physical and bent me over and rape me metaphorically speaking they didn't give me prison lube use that quote and that's how I feel about it too I'll call him B.K.O.A human traffickers extraordinaires ask Shelton Washington's dcyf I'll [...]

— WASHINGTON PARENT · JESSE

MORE VOICES FROM WASHINGTON

From the beginning, I was in a domestic violence case. I went to my local domestic violence advocate. They helped me write up a restraining order, and the judge denied it because of my ex stating that he didn't do it. I had my car repossessed, I had to have supervised visits [...]

— MISHA

depleted my resources that could have gone to kids, failed to hold my abuser accountable and rewarded him instead—even with findings of perjury and abuse on record: emotional trauma defending against false allegations against abuser and GAL in corroboration with psych evaluator.

— CHRISTINA

i have lost all access to my children who are currently 9 and 7. they were taken from my custody by their abusive father who has used money to buy his way out of being exposed for the sexual abuse he has committed upon my children. i spoke out and tried to receive help from [...]

— LEANA

The family court system very clearly took my ex abusers side. I never stood a chance. The GAL changed her recommendation the day before trial. Which is against the law. She changed her recommendation to her other parent having full custody even though he had just spent 3 years [...]

— CHEYANNE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Destroyed us emotionally. We are grieving the loss of two children. My niece was so close to her kids. She is mourning horribly

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children hate me. They were told that I abused them in many ways. I have been denied reunification.

— JENNIFER

The system took my grandson and he was abused in foster care.

— STACIE

This has destroyed the relationship between mother and child with all four of my daughters. My voice has been silenced, my kids' best interests have been ignored and this situation has even manifested into serious health concerns that I never dealt with prior.

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Purgery took my kids 12 years ago left us with 4 nights a month. Much more serious false allegations 6years ago left us completely alienated, a direct result of a corrupt system and my lack of money.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separate my family, co parent with my dv abuser, he has better job and attorney. Never has him go to drug evaluation or anger management. Financially abuse me.

— ERICA

Destroyed us completely and our future

— JONATHAN

My children don't get to see or talk to their dad, my mental state has very much been affected

— WESLEY

Has killed my 4 year old son Kannin born to Canadian mom and dad he was medically kidnapped by Seattle childrens and DCYF I have not seen my daughter in 6 years all my kids were ordered home

— ASHLEY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They're completely destroyed decimated my family my children are shells of who they were and who they should be and separated from my husband or father lost every possession we own and now I'm dying of a heart failure and a broken heart's disease

— MISTY

The system has vilified me and convinced everyone i am crazy even though I have 5 evaluations that's say I am not. It has traumatized me and my children.

— ANGILIA

My family is incomplete, separated, and I live a bittersweet nightmare called my life... With living grief and trauma to us all.

— MICHELLE

Destroyed me and my family Larry C Baker and Egypt Baker and unique Baker

— LARRY

My ex abandoned me my entire pregnancy begged me, then took me to court said I withheld our daughter and told them I was crazy. The judge believed majority of the lies and labeled me as high conflict and placed a 191 in WA on me, CPS found abuse in his home and the judge said I [...]

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This system is dragging out the abuse I spent years trying to leave while attorneys bankrupt me, and the ex lives his delusional world subjecting me to further abuse every single day.

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Douglas County Superior Court repeatedly ignored and violated court procedure and state laws in my custody case, and they continue to do so. The false testimony and allegations against me cost me custody of my 4 children, despite the exhibits of evidence I filed proving the [...]

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She is a narcissist, hellbent on punishment. The kids are the ones suffering.

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“This system shattered my family — it stole time with my children that none of us can ever get back, and it broke my faith in the Constitution and in the leaders who are supposed to protect families, not profit from their pain.”

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Broke us and stole our peace for over a decade and still ongoing.

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The CORRUPT LAKEWOOD DCYF HAS USED THEIR DEGREES AND CERTIFICATIONS TO DESTROY ME AND MY DAUGHTERS LIFE, OUR PEACE OF MIND, OUR HEARTS AND OUR HOPE FOR A BETTER TOMORROW.

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It put my children in physical harm and emotional distress , it has taken a good mother who is the only safe place away from my children . They criminally charged me for protecting my babies which now is held against me on the family side

— RIKKI

Made my son be a pawn in a war he never wanted to be

— HALLEY

Marin County, CA., King County, WA., & Carter County, TN. I was a victim and ultimate loser to Family Court in all 3 jurisdictions. Relationships with children was established only after they reached adulthood. They all feel like they lost out due to the actions taken.

— TERRANCE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This has made me a shell of a human being. It has ruined me. It has caused me to have extreme medical issues identical to broken heart syndrome. Crippling PTSD and I lost the time with my babies as babies I will never get back. Due to the abuse I was exposed too, I can never [...]

— ALLISON

This system has discredited my progress, withheld my visitations, slandered my name with all types of allegations and continue to call me things like dangerous and a threat, as well as label me as non-compliant even though there has been no court order or services ordered to me, they [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The court and system has depleted everything out of my daughter and I. By the grace of God, we are alive, but we both lost our hair from stress, but prescription hair growth has helped us at least

— MIKELA

Mine is the same story as yours, if you are reading this statement you have either been a victim of family court or are someone who can help change this system. Silencing adult and child victims to extract maximum compensation in a broken system causes irreparable harm to loving [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have made me want to rip myself apart from the stress and confusion. I am numb and tired from all of the never-ending garbage

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These individuals have acted unjustly within extreme prejudice and bias without any real concern regarding the best interest of the children. While putting children in harmful ways with individuals who were found to be abusive.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Caught in the cycle of family court over 5 years. 2 GAL's continued the case 6 times before filing a completed report. Delays and retaliatory motions have costed now over \$150k in legal fees. I've lost my business, filed bankruptcy and have been forced to go pro se. No final order [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

46 Washington parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 38 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — WASHINGTON

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Washington families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system has failed my children, took them from my care after 7 years of raising them since birth, put them in the home where they have been sexually assaulted, physically abused, and severely neglected. Their court restrained me from all contact with my children including phone calls based on lies. Judge ordered \$1200 month child support and ignored my disability and my income from ssi is on \$900. Ordered around \$10k out of pocket expenses for DV courses, psychological evaluation, supervised visits (before the mom got a restraining order), and the court knows I live 10 hour round trip from the kids now. Mom has thousands of pages of CPS reports against her but WA state HB 1227 law blocks CPS from removing children from bad homes. I get no phone calls or contact whatsoever. The mom has only had one weekend a month for years, has never paid a dime in support, never attended any functions. She has physically attacked me 3x and has done so in front of my children. The GAL failed to complete here order by only interviewing people from the mom's side. WA state cps doesn't cross county lines. There's mom is a county hopper. Three generations of the paternal side of our family has been stripped from my children and I have never had an opportunity to even hug my children goodbye. I was put into the address confidentiality program and so were my children protecting us from DV, but Pierce County over rode Spokane County and ran with the kids. I can no longer disclose my physical location to protect me, and all mail and court notifications have to go through the Secretary of Washington State. Spokane county refuses to let go of the open parenting plan in their county and said

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (1/2)

that Pierce County parenting plan is null and void and should never have been brought forth in Pierce. Spokane still holds jurisdiction. I cannot afford to comply to anything Pierce County has ordered which included supervised visits by a specific supervisor who has a two year waiting list. I was told that if I cannot comply I can have all my rights stripped from me forever. All I want to do is love and enjoy my kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT (2/2)

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Cuz Harmon my daughter mentally emotional physical and bent me over and rape me metaphorically speaking they didn't give me prison lube use that quote and that's how I feel about it too I'll call him B.K.O.A human traffickers extraordinaires ask Shelton Washington's dcyf I'll show you emails where I keep calling them this because they keep triggering my mental disability and abusing my mental rights every American disability acts reasonable accommodation you can think of for someone with a TBI they had denied seeing what the judge I'll point him out if someone wants to put in front of me because he caused more bodily harm and one day then one of my mom's boyfriends has in 10 years and they weren't even together for 10 years so put that together that's how much damage I can't trust anyone I don't believe anyone my attorneys keep throwing my case and this is a fresh case still to this day that should not be pushed as far as it is because mental rights and disability acts have been violated I have not been properly protected nor had if I had the things right to me like they're legally supposed to I have videos I can show you where they're openly admitting they won't apologize for their lies and slander straight up and I can't get legal representation cuz I'm Washington state's first reengage father that was murdered metaphorically speaking by dcyf and their slander and defamation and perjury and OPD social worker over such a boundaries and help them kill him I was just kind of curious metaphorically where they buried that body LOL sorry kind of gross Joe since you hear where I got after all these injuries and the raping dcyf is giving me as a father single with mental

— JESSE (1/4)

health issues after giving me custody Washington States what worked with me more delicately knowing of my prior mental health issues and the award I was awarded for all my hard work and dedication this just shows you what kind of sick perverted people they are please share my story it seriously needs to be heard I've reached out the local news stations and been turned away by all of them and I sent them all the same evidence I can send you today tomorrow whenever you so choose to see it man sir whoever I see a lady in the picture so I'm assuming I don't know but my story is severely needs to be heard so is my daughters we have been wronged and our bond is slowly but surely breaking because the abuse we are receiving from these people and the mental harm they're causing my daughter with falsified images and information they're subjecting her to they're not there for her they're there for the money ever he's technically mental health issues that I have she's a higher risk pay that means more the Foster caregiver and get some paid more to have her in her care then one of my family members would oh wait my family members want to get paid anything that's right cuz they don't do that anymore but please share my story when you do let me know I want to screenshot it hang it up with my burnt up award of being Washington state's first three engage father yeah that's right I burnt the award that they given me which I can also show you pictures of I can show you the certificate and the award the cheaply bought me for all the taxpayers dollars that paid for the programs all the way up to the Great Wolf Lodge expense all expenses pay a trip that I never took because of my fear social

— JESSE (2/4)

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

play and social anxiety issues and fear public places that they're well aware of and they still put me and my daughter were to stay there that I never used we burned through the funding gas voucher stuff like that \$780 and Great Wolf Lodge gift cards I had a lot of taxpayers dollars just for them to smear me like this I don't get it I don't understand it it makes life hard to live and want to live when we know we're controlled by people like this that get away with slander and lying cuz I'm sorry sticks and Stones might break my bones but it's been proven the last can kill a person if they're not strong enough is that they're not strong enough they just can't handle it anymore because their strength is taken from them got bent over and raped by dcyf like I have many times like I also show you text messages where I refer to him as of this too I also tell her my friends not trying to be gross really not at least spit on my a***** first before you freaking rape me let him glide it and not tear it open what did I ever do to deserve that s*** you know I can show you text messages like that and then they try to use it speak to text like I use here right now because my mental health issues and my disability I can't spell and when I look at the phone too long I have to worry it makes me sick I get all Worley swirly and like I've been on a roller coaster and upside down flippity pukey like a gift I was gifted that I didn't ask for at Wesley fouse from South end Auto wrecking in Renton wa got away with doing and commiing a felony assault with a baseball bat that's when my life was originally destroyed rune and everything else sadly rolled in after that the assaulted my daughter

— JESSE (3/4)

by her biological grandfather reported dcyf and they did nothing about it called the cops they did nothing about it I did what I could everything I could from my daughter and I always will I might have lose my I might have more weakness to say I want I don't want to be here no more I want to die blah blah blah that's the most everyone goes through those emotions and the one thing we are talking when we're forced to go through those programs is to express it and talk about it and what do we do we express it and talk about it then we get the crisis worse people can't help us they seriously can't ask him every time they come to my house or they call me how can we help you how can you give me a free attorney that will actually prove my innocence oh no we can't do that for you sorry didn't get the f*** out of here quit calling my phone you're going to make a crisis when there don't need to be a crisis now get the f*** on pardon my friend but seriously these are the things okay I went over two sentences I hope you read this all sorry

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From the beginning, I was in a domestic violence case. I went to my local domestic violence advocate. They helped me write up a restraining order, and the judge denied it because of my ex stating that he didn't do it. I had my car repossessed, I had to have supervised visits, the judge said I was unfit, I was to stay at her mom all of my kid's lives. My ex didn't even want to see the kids until his mom stepped in and took over. She had a lot of money I didn't. I didn't work in the marriage. My current partner's confident information was shared all over social media by my ex's mom despite requesting to be taken down by the site, emotional damage, reputational damage, overtime my time with my children got shorter and shorter and it's been almost 10 years. My ex is now alienating me from my kids and the judge will not change the parenting plan. My ex allowed my oldest son to stay because he claimed abuse and when mediation didn't go his way, he filed habeas corpus against me. This was very emotional emotionally damaging. Cps has done nothing. The judge ignores the fact that my case is domestic violence and instead continues to put me in harms way. On a whim he changed the parenting plan so that I have to go to where my ex is to pick up my kids when I am pregnant and there is domestic violence history. I am forced to pay Child Support despite not having a job so I am now in debt, and my license has been suspended twice. My ex told the school where my children are that I'm not allowed to call them so I have no contact with them. I'll calls between me and them are monitored by my ex which is against the parenting plan but the court will do nothing. I have not seen my oldest

— MISHA (1/2)

daughter for three years and she is now 18 my youngest daughter for two years and my twin daughters for a year. The system has failed me and my kids in every way possible. I hope this will cause a change because I am sick of seeing these stories online. We are good mothers, and we are telling the truth and we need to be heard.

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depleted my resources that could have gone to kids, failed to hold my abuser accountable and rewarded him instead—even with findings of perjury and abuse on record: emotional trauma defending against false allegations against abuser and GAL in corroboration with psych evaluator.

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The family court system very clearly took my ex abusers side. I never stood a chance. The GAL changed her recommendation the day before trial. Which is against the law. She changed her recommendation to her other parent having full custody even though he had just spent 3 years of her life in prison & they immediately gave him four day weekends. Trial was scheduled with out me, I missed trial and my child had to go with her other parent full time and I got every other weekend for 6 months. I secured a new attorney in this time and she got the judge to reverse his decision. I got my daughter back because i had proof of everything from doctors counselor notes, police reports of my ex pulling a gun on his new partner and the GAL told the judge she wasn't worried about my child's wellbeing. I fought for almost 3 years. 3 different attorneys. It became more and more clear the GAL knew my ex or was being compensated.

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Broke us and stole our peace for over a decade and still ongoing.

— CHRIS

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— ALLISON

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Mine is the same story as yours, if you are reading this statement you have either been a victim of family court or are someone who can help change this system. Silencing adult and child victims to extract maximum compensation in a broken system causes irreparable harm to loving parent-child relationships. This occurs daily in the pay-to-play family court horror show in America and globally. Protective parents are vilified and silenced while the abusers get custody. Same story, different family, different state, same type of actors across the board all for profit. The best interest of the child is just a slogan; not reality. I will tell our story in my upcoming book, I will never be silenced by a cold-hearted system that profited on our misery and abuse.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have done everything they can to isolate my family from each other and sold my babies never giving any options to reunite us only to keep us. All jumping through hoops achieve no progress

— ALICIA

Family Court is the Wild West of the system. Lawlessly ripping families apart for financial gain with a complete disregard for the humans effected!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined the family and zero accountability for all the inequities with the "no fault" divorce clause

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

As a egg being my family . To grow the purpose of egg is to be taken care of but no we were brutally crushed in the hands that knew better . Hands being the system. We stand no chance . For all eggs 讀諸 get crushed .

— AMY

I was cheated of 50/50 parenting time with my daughters. My daughters love me and I am a totally fit dad , yet I was still denied custody of my children. My daughters wanted 50/50 just like I did. The courts ignore the rule of clear and convincing evidence. They're just making their own rulings and not going by what's written by law

— GERARDO

I've had to stand there and defend myself against things that weren't true while losing time with my child anyway. That's the part people don't understand. The system can still take from you even when you're doing everything right.

— PORTER

My son had lived almost exclusively with me his whole life prior to the current case. This completely disrupted life as he knew it and took away all normalcy and comfort. He has been sick and injured more this year than he has the whole rest of his life combined. He now struggles with his mental health. This has traumatized him and I both.

— MIKAYLA

If you're not confused, you're not paying attention. Family court took me from someone with mild AudHD and transmuted me into someone who lost the majority of her daily life functioning, and cannot work.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

46 full approved Washington comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Washington report comes from Washington respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Washington — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 65 Washington families reporting here are not the universe of Washington families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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